

## STRATEGY OF RECORD

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# The Evolution Plan Jesse's skeleton, keel's soul

What keel takes from the category incumbent, what it refuses and why, the three moats, the eight-line constitution, and the phased roadmap A–F wired to the issues that carry it.

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keel · CodeGateSoftware/keel · owner-approved 2026-08-28→31 · amended through PR #651 · companions: docs/architecture.md, ADRs 0004–0005

**Status:** plan of record. Owner-approved across the 2026-08-28→31 delivery sessions. Amended 2026-08-31 after external review: ceremony card & idempotency binding (§5 Phase B), screening data source (§5 Phase C), Fee Reality flagship (§5 Phase E), hosted-confirm signer spike hypothesis (§5 Phase F). **Companion decisions:** ADR 0004 (monetisation, pending #603), ADR 0005 (options, pending #637). **Rule of application:** every item in this plan passes the constitution (§4) or it does not ship. The plan is subordinate to the constitution, always.

## 1. Context — what Jesse is, measured

Jesse (jesse.trade) is the category incumbent: an open-source, self-hosted Python crypto framework (public 2020), monetised through a **closed-source live-trade plugin that runs on the user's own machine** — lifetime \$899 coexisting with Free/Basic/Pro/Enterprise subscriptions, paid roadmap votes, feature sponsorship, and exchange affiliate links.

Their answers to the hard problems:

- **Privacy/custody:** solved structurally — they host nothing; keys never leave the user's machine. Their ToS even forbids using the package to run a competing cloud service.
- **Mobile/anywhere:** unsolved in eight years. No app, no PWA story; the de-facto answer is "run it on a VPS yourself."
- **Monetisation:** mature mechanics — lifetime → subscriptions with grandfathering → paid votes — but every layer landed *after* the community existed.
- **Free tier:** crippled by design (no paper trading, testnet-only live, CPU-capped research). Free is a demo.
- **Intelligence:** JesseGPT, a hosted chatbot that drafts strategies — a black box.

## 2. The synthesis rule — take / refuse

| Jesse's solution                                           | Verdict                                    | keel's version                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Never host keys; paid part runs on the user's machine      | <b>TAKE</b>                                | Zero-custody architecture; monetize trust artifacts, not hosting                         |
| Notifications free on every tier                           | <b>TAKE</b>                                | Web Push direct from the user's own engine; free forever                                 |
| "...or your AI assistant — all self-hosted" + MCP headline | <b>TAKE</b> (deferred)                     | #600 / site #118 / #119 — parked in the Deferred milestone until there are users         |
| Lifetime → subscriptions with grandfathering               | <b>TAKE the loyalty, skip the whiplash</b> | When the trigger fires: early adopters grandfathered permanently, announced as a promise |
| Deep docs/guides as growth engine                          | <b>TAKE</b>                                | Site guides grow with the research front door                                            |
| Public roadmap                                             | <b>TAKE, minus the paywall</b>             | Site #117, generated from milestones, free                                               |
| ToS reserving hosted-service rights                        | <b>TAKE the decision, consciously</b>      | Fold into Phase 6's licence choice                                                       |

| Jesse's solution                                           | Verdict                   | keel's version                                                                                                                                                     |
|------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Paid paper trading, testnet-only free, CPU-capped research | <b>REFUSE</b>             | Paper is the strongest safety default in the category — free and unlimited, forever                                                                                |
| Selling "Premium Strategies"                               | <b>REFUSE</b>             | keel's central measured finding is that no shipped rule family is net-positive at taker fees; selling strategies would sell an edge keel itself measured as absent |
| Exchange affiliate links                                   | <b>REFUSE (permanent)</b> | Fees are the binding constraint; revenue scaling with venue routing is the exact incentive that finding warns against                                              |
| Hosted GPT                                                 | <b>REFUSE, replace</b>    | Point-your-own-assistant (MCP) — better, and costs nothing to run                                                                                                  |
| Perpetual futures, margin, shorting                        | <b>REFUSE</b>             | Spot-only, cash-account posture is a category with no competitor                                                                                                   |

### 3. The three moats

1. **The honesty moat.** The evidence stack (#601's thirteen modules), the Strathern rail, published negative results. Jesse markets "is your edge real?" — keel measures it, at the fee actually paid, and can say no. This is a discipline, not a feature; it cannot be copied quickly. 2. **The anywhere/mobile moat.** Eight years and Jesse still answers "how do I use it from my phone?" with "run a VPS." keel can own this surface outright (Phase B). 3. **The intelligence moat.** keel + Ibn-Khaldun-Analyser: multi-lens historical divergence analysis wired into a compliance-gated engine *without* surrendering the decision (Phase D). Jesse's answer to intelligence is a strategy-drafting chatbot — the black box keel exists to argue against.

### 4. The constitution — every feature passes these or doesn't ship

1. A tool that cannot say no is a flattery tool. 2. Scores report and gate; they never rank (the Strathern rail). 3. Fees are priced at what was actually paid. 4. Paper is free and unlimited, forever. 5. Every attestation is human-sourced, or refused. 6. The free engine is never a demo. 7. The operator's servers never hold venue keys. 8. Negative results are published.

Every Jesse mechanic adopted in §2 passed a specific line here. Every refused one failed one.

### 5. The roadmap

#### Phase A — active queue (filed, ordered)

#595 (docs truth) → #601 ( keel research front door; adopts the in-flight console) → #437 (first-run wizard) → #602 (chart workspace) → #603 (ADR 0004, now carrying the tier table). Site: #117 (roadmap page), #120 (ADR docs sync).

## Phase B — the mobile wedge (to file; new "Anywhere access" milestone)

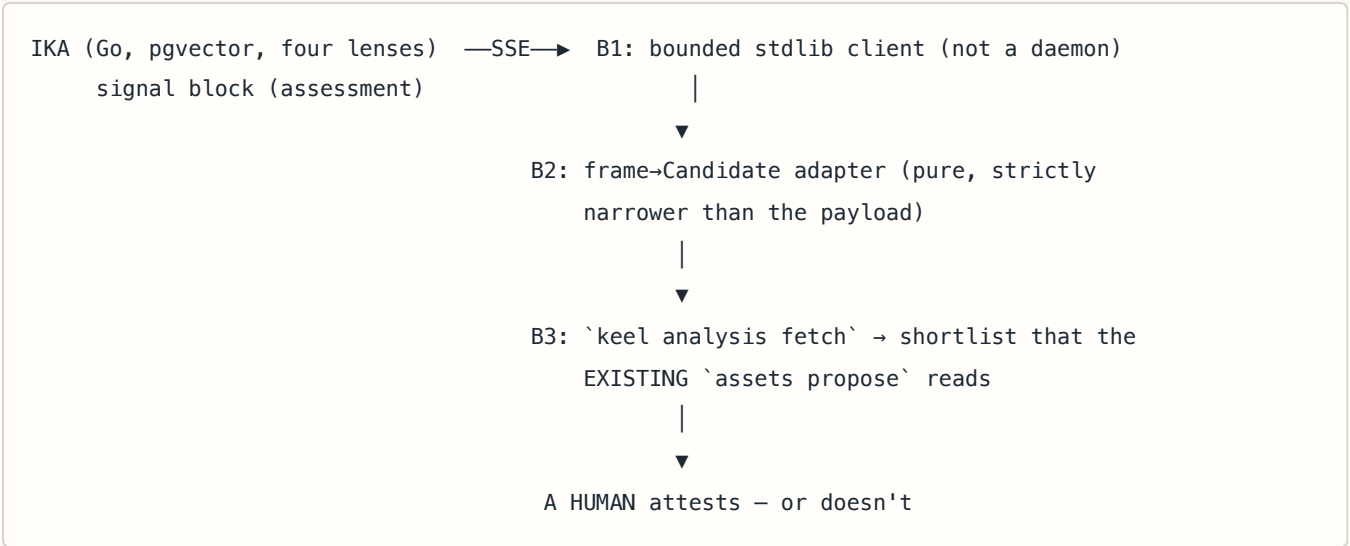
- **keel link** — one command: WireGuard mesh (Tailscale/Headscale) or Cloudflare Tunnel + Access, ACL pinned to the user's devices, QR pairing to the phone. The engine never changes; one-time session tokens stay.
- **Mobile-first PWA pass** — responsive redesign (bottom nav,  $\geq 44\text{px}$  targets), install prompt, offline shell. The phone's honest role is command surface — above all **approve/deny in confirm mode**: the ceremony's remote desk.
- **Web Push from the engine** — VAPID, direct. Greenfield, not groundwork (corrected 2026-08-31): the service worker ships for offline/manifest only — it has no push handler, no subscription endpoint, no payload encryption (RFC 8291), and the engine has no VAPID key management. All of that is new work. Prerequisite: the remote-exposure security pass (#648) — nothing remote ships before it.
- **The one-thumb ceremony card** — confirm-mode approval as a dedicated card, not a scaled-down table. v1 fields are only what exists today (fee basis at the order's clip size, purification liability, trigger rationale); a spread vital sign arrives only with #626's data capture — a number invented for the UI would be a constitution violation. Confirmations carry `idempotency_key` + `proposal_hash`, both; a mismatch is refused and proposals expire — so a retried approval over a flapping tunnel deduplicates cleanly, and a replayed key can never approve a regenerated proposal.
- **The price-drift gate** — an async approval is not a fresh quote: the envelope also carries `price_at_proposal` and a per-product drift tolerance. **Entries** exceeding it are refused with a named code and re-proposed at the next cycle; **exits are never walled off** — they degrade to the typed-phrase friction path, the same principle `_ask_to_place` already documents (trapping a position behind a gate is a worse money outcome than a warned order). The tolerance is derived — per-product, from measured spread once #626's capture lands — never a flat constant: a chosen number is the #523 mistake in miniature.

Why this and not a hosted app: a hosted executor can never honestly say "we can't see your data" — the operator ships the code that runs beside the plaintext keys. The only architectures that keep the promise are the ones where the keys never reach our servers.

## Phase C — asset-class breadth (elevated)

- **Equities via Alpaca** — finish #370/#371. The completion bar now explicitly includes equity screening + purification extension (debt ratios, impermissible-revenue shares, human-sourced attestations) and cost fidelity *before* the live paper flip (#571's lesson applied to a new asset class). Screening measures from **SEC XBRL companyfacts** — AAOIFI 33/33/5 thresholds, a pinned quarterly snapshot under the #523 pin/re-pin discipline; the module measures, the human attests (recorded on #370). No third-party SaaS screening black box. Being first with honestly-costed, compliance-gated stocks next to crypto is a differentiator Jesse structurally cannot copy.
- **Phase 13 Binance** — #564–#568, after Alpaca proves the pattern.
- **Options** — a constitution decision, not a feature. Three collisions: the shipped `CashAccountRequired` rail (multiplier == 1, #372), the spot-only/no-leverage stance, the default-refused screen. If amended, the narrowest defensible slice is cash-secured only (covered calls, cash-secured puts), exception-gated unscreened book, `posture: exceptions` in every report, its own ADR (0005) with a reopen trigger. Sequenced after #370 lands and #636's venue-reality findings are in. Default posture until then: cash-spot only.

Phase D — Ibn-Khaldun-Analyser integration (#570–#578)



- The rail extends to the feed (C1's AST pins): no IKA field may ever become a ranking key, an auto-admission, or an order input.
- C2's operator guide carries the sentence this implies: **you must not attest out of persuasion** — an attestation sourced "the feed said so" is refused exactly like an unsourced one.
- A1 before money: measure crypto relevance before buying the Desk tier. IKA reads macro/geopol; its crypto bearing must be measured, not assumed.
- B4: an entitlement lapse reads as "feed silent," never "market quiet."
- C3: the keep-paying decision, measured and published either way.
- Config is `analysis_feed:`, never `subscription:` (rail 14).

Phase E — open source & discoverability (Phase 6 objective)

Licence choice (permissive + trademark posture + the reserve-hosted-rights decision), README written for the GitHub audience, awesome-lists (site #14) and handles (site #15). Jesse's eight-year GitHub presence is their entire funnel; keel's is unstarted. The cheapest growth lever on the board. Its flagship is the **Fee Reality benchmark** (#646 + site #136): the negative result, reproducible from recorded runs, as the README's opening hook — every number rendered from the ledger or it does not ship, and no competitor named in the asset.

Phase F — monetisation (trigger-gated; recorded in ADR 0004)

| Tier                       | Price (USD-eq, crypto-only) | What it buys                                                                                                                                         | The promise                              |
|----------------------------|-----------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Free                       | \$0, forever                | The full engine. Never a demo.                                                                                                                       | We see nothing                           |
| Pro — "your box, anywhere" | \$14/mo · \$140/yr prepay   | managed <code>keel link</code> , signed+notarized installers (the #438 certs become Pro value), managed updates, Web Push plumbing, priority support | We can't see your data                   |
| Founder — lifetime         | \$399, first 200, then gone | Everything in Pro, forever, founder badge                                                                                                            | Grandfathering is a promise, not a promo |

| Tier                                           | Price (USD-eq, crypto-only)     | What it buys                                                            | The promise              |
|------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------|
| <b>Hosted-confirm — "our brain, your keys"</b> | \$49/mo · \$450/yr (built last) | Full hosted engine; your device holds the keys and approves every order | We can see, we can't act |

- **Payment is crypto-only**, via self-hosted non-custodial BTCPay (#638): USD-priced at spot, prepaid credit (no auto-charge exists on-chain), Lightning for small recurring amounts, the invoice ledger as the audit trail. Chosen because it coheres with promises already made: no interest-bearing rails, no processor that sees the payer, no chargeback asymmetry. US reality stated plainly: crypto-only removes the processor, not the tax — receipt is ordinary income at fair-market value.
- **Hosted-confirm's signer** — one substantial new artifact, in either shape: (a) a small native signer app (Swift Keychain / Android Keystore, biometric-gated), or (b) the 2026-08-31 hypothesis — venue keys held in the PWA as **non-extractable WebCrypto keys**, passkey-gated (the biometric unlocks the signing call; a passkey authenticates, it cannot sign an order), with the hosted engine as a **dumb relay** for fully-signed requests: browsers cannot call venue APIs directly (origin blocks), so the engine forwards bytes it can withhold but never forge. Caveats named honestly — IndexedDB is not a Keychain; venue signing algorithms must exist in WebCrypto; replay protection needs timestamps/nonces; and a malicious engine can still *propose* differently: socialize, not steal. Shape (b) is settled by a validation spike before any commitment, not by decision.
- **No classic SaaS tier**. If full-autonomy hosting is ever demanded, it ships labeled with Jesse's privacy tradeoff, not with a promise keel cannot make.
- The reopen trigger is unchanged and recorded in ADR 0004: **users, not revenue**.

## 6. Standing decisions already made on the way here

- **MCP surfacing deferred** (#600 → Deferred milestone) until there are users to serve.
- **Desktop signing stays off** (Option D on #438): unsigned at \$0; activation is a secrets-drop; if only one platform is bought, macOS first. The certs are Pro-tier value.
- **Repo boundary**: app issues live in CodeGateSoftware/keel (project *keel*); site-only issues live in CodeGateSoftware/keeltrading.com (project *KeelTrading*). No issue carries another repo's work in its checklist.

## 7. The thesis

Jesse built the category's best *terminal* and monetized it by walling off capability. keel becomes better by being the category's honest *instrument* — evidence that can say no, compliance gates that stay in human hands, access from any device without custody, and intelligence from IKA that informs without instructing — and monetizes trust itself: signing, updates, access, support. Jesse's product asks to be trusted with your money; keel's is designed so it never has to be.

